

1.9 Nonverbal Communication: Casual Attire at Work (L.O. 3)

Communication Technology

E-Mail

Social Media

Team

Web

Although many employers allow casual attire, not all employers and customers are happy with the results. To learn more about the implementation, acceptance, and effects of casual-dress programs, select one of the following activities, all of which involve some form of interviewing.

YOUR TASK.

- In teams, gather information from human resources directors to determine which companies allow casual or dress-down days, how often, and under what conditions. The information may be collected by personal interviews, e-mail, telephone, or instant messaging.
- In teams, conduct inquiring-reporter interviews. Ask individuals in the community how they react to casual dress in the workplace. Develop a set of standard interview questions.
- Compare and contrast the effects of business-dress standards on such factors as the projected image of the company, the nature of the interactions with customers and with fellow employees, the morale of employees, and the productivity of employees. What generalizations can you draw from your findings?

1.10 Nonverbal Communication Around the World (L.O. 3, 4)

Intercultural

Web

Whenever people communicate, gestures play an important role. Because culture shapes the meaning of gestures, miscommunication and misunderstanding can easily result in international situations.

YOUR TASK. Use the Internet to research the meanings of selected gestures. Make a list of ten gestures (other than those discussed in the text) that have different meanings in different countries. Consider the fingertip kiss, nose thumb, eyelid pull, nose tap, head shake, and other gestures. How are the meanings different in other countries? Can you name neutral symbols that have changed meaning because they were appropriated by a certain political group (think the index-finger-thumb pinch—the OK sign)? Which gestures that are innocent in the United States are considered vulgar and offensive in other countries?

1.11 Intercultural Communication: Watching Those Corporate Clichés (L.O. 4)

Intercultural

The language of business is rife with jargon and clichés—once-fashionable idiomatic expressions that become stale and lose meaning. They sound particularly murky to the uninitiated.

YOUR TASK. Translate the annoying buzzwords into plain English.²² Assume that you are explaining them to nonnative speakers of English.

- low-hanging fruit
- circle back
- move the needle
- bite the bullet
- at the end of the day
- think outside the box
- peel back (the layers of) the onion
- par for the course
- throw someone under the bus

1.12 Intercultural Communication: Analyzing Cultural Stereotypes (L.O. 4, 5)

Intercultural

Team

Web

Almost all of us at some point in our lives are subject to stereotyping by others, whether we are immigrants, communities of color, women, members of certain professions, or Americans abroad. Negative stereotypes sting. However, even presumably positive stereotypes can offend or embarrass because they deny people's individuality and uniqueness. If we remain open to new experiences, we won't be limited by rigid, stereotypical perceptions of other cultures.

YOUR TASK. Think about a nation or culture about which you have only a hazy idea. Jot down a few key traits that come to mind. For example, you may not know much about the Netherlands and the Dutch people. You can probably think of gouda cheese, wooden clogs, Heineken beer, tulips, and windmills. Anything else? Then consider a culture with which you are very familiar,

whether it is yours or that of a country you visited or studied. In one column, write down a few stereotypical perceptions that are positive. Then, in another column, record negative stereotypes you associate with that culture. Share your notes with your team or the whole class, as the instructor may direct. How do you respond to others' descriptions of your culture? Which stereotypes irk you and why? For a quick fact check and overview at the end of this exercise, google the CIA World Factbook or BBC News Country Profiles.

1.13 Learning From Epic Intercultural Fails (L.O. 4, 5)

Intercultural

As business organizations become increasingly global in their structure and marketing, they face communication problems resulting from cultural misunderstandings. They also must deal with culture clashes and radically different values around the world.

YOUR TASK. Based on what you have learned in this chapter, describe several broad principles that could be applied in helping the individuals involved understand what went wrong in the following events. What suggestions could you make for remedying the problems?

- Social media leaders are not immune to intercultural missteps that go viral. Twitter CEO Jack Dorsey landed in hot water in India for posing with a group of female activists and holding a controversial sign. The slogan "Smash Brahminical Patriarchy" caused outrage because it is calling for the dismantling of the Hindu caste system and male dominance with it. Many Twitter users called it hate speech and were furious. Twitter publicly apologized but then reaped criticism for caving in to the ruling class and silencing marginalized voices.⁴¹
- When Susan Kramer served as the British transportation minister, she faced embarrassment after presenting the mayor of Taipei, Taiwan, Ko Wen-je, with a watch—a taboo in Chinese culture. Ko remarked to reporters that he would "sell it to a scrap dealer" because a watch would be useless to him. Giving a clock and attending an old person's funeral sound very similar in Chinese.⁴²
- During a state dinner for a delegation from Singapore visiting the government of the Czech Republic, the conversation turned to the tasty main course they were eating. One of the Czech hosts explained to the inquiring foreign guests that they were enjoying a Czech specialty, rabbit, known for its light white meat. The Singaporeans' faces mirrored shock, embarrassment, and irritation. As inconspicuously as possible, they put down their silverware. Only later did the Czech hosts learn that rabbit is a pet in Singapore much like the house cat in European or North American households.⁴³
- More than half of Japanese hotels do not allow guests with tattoos in their onsens, or hot spring bathing facilities. Some operators do, but only if the guests cover up their body art. In Japan tattoos are associated with organized crime. The bans were put in place to keep yakuza gangsters out and to prevent complaints from Japanese guests. A controversy erupted when a Māori woman (a member of the Indigenous Polynesian People from New Zealand) was barred from a public bath in Hokkaido for her traditional face tattoos.⁴⁴ Critics of the restrictive Japanese policies pointed out the pervasive presence of tattoos in many Western countries.

1.14 Intercultural Missteps and Bias Amplified on Social Media (L.O. 4, 5)

Intercultural Social Media

Once a gaffe blows up on social media, it is difficult to contain. Consider the worst, most embarrassing intercultural mistake or bigotry incident, and then imagine it amplified a thousandfold or millionfold for everyone to see. What follows is a list of diversity and inclusion blunders as well as awkward social media slip-ups with intercultural implications.⁴⁵

YOUR TASK. Consider the gravity of each offense; then, individually or in groups, discuss each for its take-away, the lesson to be learned from it.

- In a case of awful timing, WW, formerly Weight Watchers, released a New Year's campaign #ThisIsMyWW on Twitter just as the United States launched a targeted drone strike that killed Iran's top general, Qasem Soleimani in Iraq, causing international consternation. Thus, WW's promoted trend campaign clashed with the unfortunate trending hashtag WWII (for World War II). The company immediately pulled its campaign and Twitter helped by removing the promoted trend within one hour of its launch. Even so, more than 870,000 people would belabor the topic over the course of three days on Twitter alone.⁴⁶
- Papa John's pizza company forced out its founder and CEO, John Schnatter, after he had used a racial slur and made other racially tinged comments during a conference call with executives and the company's advertising agency. Predictably, his remarks made it onto social media, and Papa John's sales dropped 10.5 percent in the following weeks.
- Two African American men were arrested at a Philadelphia Starbucks, the victims of apparent racial bias. The two men were waiting for an associate and asked to use the restroom without making a purchase. The situation escalated, and police were called. Social media blew up with negative tweets. Starbucks' brand perception among customers plummeted to its lowest in ten years. Starbucks closed 8,000 U.S. stores for sensitivity training.

1.15 Intercultural Communication: Fired for Being French? (L.O. 4, 5)

E-Mail

Intercultural

Team

Guillaume Rey was dismissed from his Vancouver restaurant job after warnings that he was being “combative and aggressive” toward other staff. When he reduced a fellow server to tears over a disagreement, he was let go for violating workplace policy. The Milestones restaurant admitted that Rey was professional and friendly with guests and often served as shift lead. The waiter filed a complaint with British Columbia’s Human Rights Tribunal. He alleged discrimination and claimed that French culture “tends to be more direct and expressive.” He insisted he was let go for having acquired high standards in France along with a “direct, honest and professional personality.”

An employment consultant in British Columbia agrees that most French-speaking people from Europe tend to be direct, whereas Canadians are steeped in a non-conflict culture, particularly on the job. A French expatriate living in London believes that many French dislike chitchat such as talking about the weather. They get to the point. Talking or even smiling at strangers strikes them as intrusive, she says.¹⁸

YOUR TASK. Critically analyze the scenario in small teams or as a class. If your instructor directs, write a discussion forum post or an e-mail evaluating the intercultural encounter. Consider questions such as the following to get to the bottom the controversy:

What is the fundamental conflict here? Was Guillaume Rey a competent waiter? Do you find his claims and his defense credible? Does his official complaint have merit? Did the restaurant act reasonably? In how far is the incident an intercultural one? Is it the result of a cultural misunderstanding?

Grammar/Mechanics Checkup 1

These checkups are designed to improve your grammar and mechanics skills, which include punctuation, spelling, capitalization, and number use. The checkups systematically review all sections of the Grammar/Mechanics Handbook. Answers are provided at the bottom of the page. You can find accompanying student resources at www.cengage.com.

NOUNS

Review Sections 1.02–1.06 in the Grammar/Mechanics Handbook. Then select the correct form to complete each of the following statements. Record the appropriate Grammar/Mechanics section to illustrate the principle involved. When you finish, compare your responses with those at the bottom of the page. If your answers differ, study carefully the principles shown in parentheses.

b (1.05b)

EXAMPLE The delivery driver arrived in the afternoon and unloaded the (a) box's, (b) boxes.

1. In Spanish Buenos Aires means good air, but the beautiful capital of Argentina is among the ten most polluted big (a) citys, (b) cities.
2. The (a) CPAs (b) CPA's we hired to do our taxes work tirelessly during tax season.
3. The two freshly minted (a) attornies, (b) attorneys lost their case although they had mounted a masterful defense.
4. Are you available to coach basketball on (a) Mondays, (b) Monday's?
5. (a) Turkiies, (b) Turkeys bred rapidly in factory farms can barely walk.
6. The Garzas and the (a) Ramirez's, (b) Ramirezes prefer to take the whole family to the park instead of the beach.
7. The United States Environmental Protection Agency was established in the (a) 1970's, (b) 1970s.
8. (a) Mothers-in-law, (b) Mother-in-laws don't deserve the negative reputation attributed to them in popular culture.
9. Iron (a) benches, (b) benches are not comfortable without cushions, but they last a long time.
10. The IRS requested copies of all documents showing the company's assets and (a) liability's, (b) liabilities.

- _____ 11. The department decided to send the newlyweds a large bouquet of (a) peonys, (b) peonies, their favorite flowers.
- _____ 12. With Google Earth you can visit any mountains and (a) volleys (b) vallies on this planet.
- _____ 13. Credit (a) inquirys, (b) inquiries help banks determine whether to grant loans to applicants.
- _____ 14. When it's sunny and I'm outside, I can't tell the difference between (a) i's and I's, (b) on my tablet.
- _____ 15. My sister-in-law joined several (a) woman, (b) women in her circle who were inspired by Greta Thunberg to fight against climate change.